The Gin Game

By D.L. Coburn

FONSIA: *(enters, seemingly lost in thought; she starts at unexpectedly seeing Weller) (embarrassed)* Oh, I . . . I didn't think anyone was out her.

WELLER: I'm sorry I startled you. You're rather new here, aren't' you?

FONSIA: Three weeks.

WELLER: It takes some adjustment.

FONSIA: How long have you been here?

WELLER: Couple of months. Of course, it's not the first time I've lived in. They're all pretty much alike.

FONSIA: I came here to Bentley because they're supposed to have constant care.

WELLER: What's wrong with you – if . . . if you don't mind my asking.

FONSIA: Oh, my . . . Lord no, I don't mind. I've got chronic diabetes. Is there something wrong with you? . . . I mean are you sick?

WELLER: Oh my, I should say so. I have one of the most advanced cases of old age in the history of medical science. *(Pause)* The mortality rate's incredible. If you live long enough, sooner or later you end up in one of these places.

FONSIA: I guess you're right. 'Course, if you were rich enough . . .

WELLER: Don't be deluded by money. I've seen some very wealthy people in old age homes. Lonliness – simple as that. Do you play cards?

FONSIA: Oh, it's been years since I've played any cards. I used to love to play. I could sit and play rummy 'til two o'clock in the morning. *(Amused)* If my mother'd ever know I was doing that, she'd a killed me. We were raised old-time Methodist and we considered card playin' a sin.

WELLER: The only sin in card playing is drawing to an inside straight. And even that's not a sin if you fill it. *(He laughs at his own twist of logic)* Did you ever play gin?

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(picks up a deck of cards and begins to shuffle) By the way, I'm Weller Martin.

FONSIA: Fonsia Dorsey. Is gin and rummy the same? Seems to me they called it gin rummy.

WELLER: Here, I'll show you. Now then . . . the first thing we do is deal the cards. Ten for me and eleven for you. *(Dealing ritual)* One, one, Two, two . . . .

INTRODUCTION

When two elderly people are young at heart, relationships develop quickly. A simple game of gin can become a friendship. Unless . . . one of those people has an unnatural need to win. To Fonsia, it's just a game of gin; but to Weller it is obviously so much more and his reactions dredge up issues for Fonsia as well. The Gin Game by D.L. Coburn.

WELLER: You think you got it now? *(Fonsia nods enthusiastically)* Good, then let's play!

(They pick up their cards, arrange them in their hands and begin to play the game. Through the following dialogue, the play of the hand proceeds normally)

FONSIA: I thought this was going to be an awful day. I'm actually enjoying myself.

WELLER: Visitor's Day! *(snorts)* Do you have any family?

FONSIA: Oh, my yes. Of course. I have a son almost forty-five years old . . . Larry. Then I have a sister, Hattie. I haven't seen her in fifteen years.

WELLER: Does your son live here in town.

FONSIA: No. Ah . . . he hand his wife make their home in Denver. Do you have any children? . . . Wait a minute. I'm sorry, Weller. I think I'm sitting here with gin in my hand already. Four kings, 3 nines and the five, six and seven of spades. I've got the eight too. I guess I just discard that.

WELLER: *(decidedly displeased at being beaten in the first hand – patronizing)* That's right. Very good. Very good, Fonsia. Forty-two points in the first game. *(He gathers the cards and begins to shuffle)*

FONSIA: Beginner's luck, I guess. Oh. I was just about to ask you about your children.

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WELLER: *(Weller deals the cards again)* One, one, two, two . . . . *(continues dealing while he speaks and the card game should resume)* I have three children . . . Divorced. Their mother didn't exactly encourage a close relationship between us. She moved – she and the children – to another city. I had a business established so I couldn't follow them. Eventually she remarried, so that was more or less the end of that.

FONSIA: I'm sorry that happened to you. Of course, that's exactly what some men deserve. That would've suited the one I had just right.

WELLER: *(Bitter)* It doesn't suit anyone just right. I wouldn't wish it on him either.

FONSIA: Well, if you knew the hell I went through, you'd change your tune might fast on that! (Pause) Gin! . . . That was lucky – I got everything I needed right away.

WELLER: *(disgusted look at a quick second loss as he picks up the cards and shuffles again)* Does the food around here give you diarrhea?

FONSIA: Weller!

WELLER: That's a legitimate question. *(The gin game continues throughout the conversation)*

FONSIA: *(changing the subject)* What kind of business were you in?

WELLER: Basically I told people who to run their business. I remember when I was just getting started in business, I wanted a job from this particular company. The president said, "What's it going to cost us?" Well, I was afraid to ask for much money at that time. I though the job was worth about five hundred – but I cut it back to four. I was so nervous, I just said the word, "Four." The president, he turned to one of the other men and said, "Does four thousand sound in line to you, Harry?" The guy said, "Yeah, that sounds about right to me."

FONSIA: *(Disbelieving)* Weller, you're making that up! Gin!

WELLER: *(gathering cards to shuffle and deal again)* Goddamn it. I knew you were keeping jacks. Now what'd I do that more. I gave it right to you. Talking too damned much.

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FONSIA: *(prim and proper)* You know, I never heard my father say a curse word in his life.

WELLER: Obviously you didn't play gin with him! *(hears something from off stage)* What the hell are they doing in there now? I just can't understand this "entertainment." Sometimes I get the idea that they feel like if they don't have a choir up there or if they don't have a goddamn magician up there doing trick or something – then we're all going to drop dead right in front of their eyes. . . . I should just know while I've got a chance. You're probably sitting over there with gin already.

FONSIA: Not quite *(game continues in silence except for Weller)*

WELLER: *(draws card)* Nothing *(Fonsia draws and keeps it for her hand; Weller draws again)* Nothing *(Fonsia draws and keeps it for her hand; Weller draws)* Nothing. *(Fonsia draws)*

FONSIA: There it is. Gin!

WELLER: *(Throws his card down)* I don't believe it! Let me see that! *(Fonsia displays her cards and a complete rage follows)* AW! BULLSHIT! BULLSHIT! *(Weller stops away then stops back to look at the cards again).* AW! JESUS CHRIST. *(He sweeps the cards wildly into the air and Fiona recoils.)*

FONSIA: Weller!

*************Scene break ****************

TRANSITION

A few days pass until Weller once again meets Fonsia on the sun porch.

WELLER: *(Sheepishly approaching Fonsia)* I'll get right to the point, Fonsia . . I owe you an apology

FONSIA: Yes you do! *(Weller holds up a deck of cards and begins to shuffle a querulous expression on his face)* Now, Weller, I'm NOT going to play any gin with you.

WELLER: Oh come on, Fonsie, for God's sake. . . . All right, don't play. Go on back in there

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with all those glassy-eyed old bastards.

FONSIA: God, you're cynical. It's just the mercy of God that we're able to get around a little better than they are. They're just sick, that's all.

WELLER: They're not half as sick as the ones who put them here. And they're not a third as sick as this bunch that's supposed to be taking care of them.

FONSIA: You've got a horrible temper . . . and a sarcastic streak.

WELLER: *(Defensively, cutting her off)* If I were you, I wouldn't be talking about anybody's else's shortcomings.

FONSIA: What's that supposed to mean?

WELLER: Well, neither one of us is winning any popularity contest out here on visitor's day.

FONSIA: Oh. I see. No one visits me so I'm an evil person?

WELLER: Why doesn't your son visit you?

FONSIA: I think I should go in.

WELLER: All right, goddamn it, go ahead. I don't see how you can stand it in there. . The same damn empty look, face after face. You ought to see them on the days when the bed linens are changed. All lined up in those wheelchairs, all up and down the halls . . . like rows of wrinkled pumpkin heads.

FONSIA: Maybe we could play a few hands . . . You're just going to pester me 'til I play anyway. *(Weller grins and the card game begins)* Now if I win, don't you shout at me.

WELLER: You play your best, damn it! I won't have you trying to lose . . . just to appease poor Weller. I'm one of the best gin players you'll ever see and I sure as hell don't need any help from you. Play your cards, damn it! *(Pause – Weller continues in calmer affected tone).* I'm sorry. Please play your cards.

FONSIA: Just play your cards, Weller.

WELLER: *(Mimicking)* Just play your cards, Weller. Well, aren't we getting tough.

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FONSIA: Not tough. Just tired. Very tired.

WELLER: Aw for Christ's sake, come on. *(Pause)* Goddamn it!

FONSIA: Every other breath you draw has to be a curse word doesn't it?

WELLER: *(Pause)* Shit! *(Fonsia draws a card, puts it in her hand, then, saying nothing and without discarding, she displays her hand face up on the table. She doesn't look up. Weller scrutinizes the cards then shouts)* SAY IT!!! *(Fonsia says nothing. Weller paces angrily away then turns on her and in a shouting, accusatory tone, continues)* YOU'VE GOT IT. GODDAMN IT – SAY IT!!! *(Still no response from Fonsia; Weller marches over to her and shouts directly in her face)* SAY IT!

FONSIA: *(barely audible)* Gin.

WELLER: CHRIST, YOU CAN SAY IT LOUDER THAN THAT! I CAN HARDLY EVEN HEAR YOU!

FONSIA: *(Shouting to match Weller's tone)* GIN—GODDAMN IT!!! GIN!!! *(long pause while they both catch their breaths)* It was a game, Weller. You lost – it's over – so forget it.

WELLER: Well . . . suppose I want to play you again.

FONSIA: Nothing doing! The minute you lost, it'd be the same thing all over again. I may be old, but I'm not crazy. I've never seen a man get so . . . so wild . . . over a game of cards in my life. It's not natural, Weller, there's something wrong.

WELLER: I know all about how you think something's wrong with me. They called me down the office last Tuesday and said they were thinking about having a psychiatrist come out here and talk to me. Do you know what they could do if he says there's something wrong with my mind? They could have me committed to the state mental hospital. The very fact that you complained makes me a troublemaker.

FONSIA: You could need help and not know it. All I was trying to do was to help you. Maybe I shouldn't have said anything. . . NO, if I didn't say anything, the next thing you know they'd find one of us out here on the floor.

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WELLER: What do you think I'm going to do? Hit you over the head? Good God, you make harsh judgments, Fonsia. I'm a potential murderer? I'm crazy. I'm vulgar. According to you I'm a hopeless sinner for taking the Lord's name all the time. You know what wrong with most people in the world? . . . they've got a mother who's just like you.

FONSIA: That's the most insulting remark I've ever heard in my life.

WELLER: I know why Larry doesn't visit you. It doesn't have a damn thing to do with Denver . . . or distance . . . or job. I know what it is now. You've made him feel like the lowest piece of crap on earth for so long he can't stand the sight of you. He hates you.

FONSIA: THAT'S NOT TRUE! AND I WON'T HAVE YOU TALK TO ME LIKE THAT!!!

WELLER: He's never done anything right, has he? He's never done a thing on this earth to please you, has he.

FONSIA: STOP IT, WELLER. I'M WARNING YOU.

WELLER: He doesn't even live in Denver, does he? Your son lives right her in town and you know it!

FONSIA: He does not hate me! He doesn't hate me!

WELLER: Then why doesn't he visit you? Why does he totally ignore his own mother?

FONSIA: How did you know he lives here?

WELLER: I didn't I was guessing.

FONSIA: Guessing! YOU BASTARD. YOU BASTARD *(Fonsia weeps hysterically)*

WELLER: Fonsie. Fonsie. Fonsie. I'm sorry. I'm sorry. .

FONSIA: I know who he takes after. His father was as rotten as they come. I always hoped Larry'd be different. Sometimes I think he does hate me . . . I don't know.

WELLER: Just relax yourself. You're only doing yourself harm. What you need is to get your mind off him. *(Gathers up the cards and begins to shuffle)* Come on, I'll play you a hand of gin. *(Cajoling)* You can't tell me you didn't enjoy beating me game

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after game, watching me get angrier and angrier. – We'll play one hand . . .

FONSIA: Deal.

WELLER: *(Dealing)* One, one, Two, two, Three, three

TOGETHER: Four, four, Five, five

WELLER: I'm going to beat you this hand . . . . By God, I'm going to beat you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: D.L. Coburn
ISBN: 978-0573609763
Publisher: Samuel French
Date (Month/Year): 1977

AWARD HISTORY

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